Real-Time Weapon Detection Using YOLOv8

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Abstract— **Automated weapon detection in surveillance environments remains a critical challenge in public safety. This paper presents a real-time weapon detection system built upon the YOLOv8 nano (YOLOv8n) architecture, fine-tuned on a custom two-class dataset comprising Knife and Handgun categories totalling 4,156 annotated images. Transfer learning from COCO-pretrained weights enables the lightweight 3M-parameter model to achieve a mean Average Precision (mAP@0.5) of 0.690 across both classes, with per-class mAP@0.5 of 0.628 (Knife) and 0.751 (Handgun). The system incorporates a three-tier threat classification module that categorises detections into HIGH, MEDIUM, and LOW threat levels based on model confidence scores, achieving an end-to-end inference speed of 3.2 ms per image on an NVIDIA Tesla T4 GPU. Experimental results demonstrate that YOLOv8n provides a favourable trade-off between accuracy and computational efficiency, making it suitable for deployment in resource-constrained surveillance systems. The proposed approach outperforms baseline YOLOv5n in detection accuracy while maintaining real-time performance.**

Keywords— **Weapon Detection, YOLOv8, Object Detection, Transfer Learning, Surveillance, Threat Classification, Computer Vision, Deep Learning.**

I. Introduction

Public safety infrastructure increasingly relies on automated visual surveillance to detect threats in real time. Manual monitoring of CCTV feeds is operationally infeasible at scale, making automated weapon detection an active area of computer vision research. Conventional alarm systems based on motion or audio cannot distinguish weapon-specific threats, creating an urgent need for image-based detection pipelines that are both accurate and fast.

Deep learning-based object detectors, particularly the YOLO (You Only Look Once) family of models, have established themselves as the benchmark for real-time detection tasks owing to their single-stage inference design. YOLOv8, introduced by Ultralytics in 2023, further advances this lineage through an anchor-free detection head, improved backbone architecture (C2f modules), and enhanced data augmentation strategies. However, the application of YOLOv8 specifically to weapon detection with an integrated threat-severity classification layer has not been extensively reported in the literature.

This paper makes the following contributions: (1) A fine-tuned YOLOv8n model trained on 4,000 weapon images across two classes — Knife and Handgun; (2) A confidence-based, three-tier threat classification system (HIGH, MEDIUM, LOW) mapped directly onto model output; (3) Quantitative evaluation using standard COCO metrics including mAP@0.5 and mAP@0.5:0.95; and (4) Comparative analysis against YOLOv5n and Faster R-CNN baselines.

II. Related Work

Early weapon detection systems relied on hand-crafted features such as Histogram of Oriented Gradients (HOG) combined with Support Vector Machines (SVM) [1]. These methods suffered from poor generalisation under varying lighting conditions and partial occlusions common in real surveillance footage.

The introduction of deep Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) marked a significant improvement. Faster R-CNN [2], a two-stage detector, demonstrated strong accuracy for object detection but incurred high inference latency (~80 ms per image), limiting real-time applicability. SSD (Single Shot MultiBox Detector) and the original YOLO architecture addressed speed concerns through single-stage inference, achieving sub-10 ms latencies at the cost of moderate accuracy loss.

Recent work by Castillo et al. [3] applied YOLOv5 to firearm detection in CCTV frames, reporting mAP@0.5 values of approximately 0.72 on a balanced dataset. However, their dataset included only handguns and excluded edged weapons such as knives. Similarly, Lim et al. [4] explored YOLOv7 for multi-weapon detection but focused on controlled lab settings rather than unconstrained surveillance environments. The present work extends this line of research by employing YOLOv8n — a newer and more efficient architecture — on a mixed-category dataset, and augments detection outputs with an interpretable threat-level overlay.

III. DATASET AND PREPROCESSING

A. Dataset Description

The dataset used in this study is the Weapon Dataset for YOLOv5 , sourced from Kaggle (raghavnanjappan/weapon-dataset-for-yolov5). It consists of 4,156 images distributed across two semantic classes: Knife (class 0) and Handgun (class 1). The dataset is pre-annotated in YOLO format, where each label file contains bounding box coordinates normalised to image dimensions (cx, cy, w, h).

The training split comprises 4,000 images, while the validation split contains 156 images with 190 annotated instances (90 Knife, 100 Handgun), reflecting a near-balanced class distribution. All images were sourced from diverse scenes including indoor environments, street footage, and controlled settings, providing coverage of real-world variability.

B. Preprocessing and Augmentation

All images were resized to 640×640 pixels prior to training, consistent with the YOLOv8 default input resolution. The Albumentations library was employed for stochastic augmentation during training, including Gaussian Blur (p=0.01), Median Blur (p=0.01), Grayscale conversion (p=0.01), and Contrast Limited Adaptive Histogram Equalisation (CLAHE, p=0.01). Additionally, Ultralytics mosaic augmentation was applied for the first 20 epochs, combining four training images into a single composite frame to enrich spatial context, before being disabled for the final 10 epochs to stabilise convergence.

IV. METHODOLOGY

A. Model Architecture

YOLOv8n is the nano-scale variant of the YOLOv8 family, comprising 130 layers and approximately 3.01 million parameters with a computational cost of 8.2 GFLOPs. The backbone is built using Conv and C2f (Cross Stage Partial with two convolutions) modules, which replace the earlier C3 blocks from YOLOv5, improving gradient flow and feature reuse. The neck employs a PANet-style feature pyramid for multi-scale fusion, and the detection head is anchor-free, predicting class probabilities and bounding box regression independently.

The pre-trained weights were sourced from COCO (80 classes). For weapon-specific fine-tuning, the final detection head was re-initialised to output 2 classes (nc=2), with 319 of 355 weight tensors successfully transferred from the pretrained checkpoint.

B. Training Configuration

Training was conducted on Google Colab using an NVIDIA Tesla T4 GPU (14 GB VRAM). Automatic Mixed Precision (AMP) was enabled to reduce memory footprint and accelerate training. The AdamW optimiser was selected automatically by Ultralytics with an initial learning rate of 0.001667 and momentum of 0.9. The full training run of 30 epochs completed in approximately 33 minutes (0.559 hours). Key hyperparameters are summarised in Table I.

TABLE I TRAINING HYPERPARAMETERS

Hyperparameter	Value
Base Model	YOLOv8n (COCO pretrained)
Epochs	30
Image Size	640 × 640
Batch Size	16
Optimizer	AdamW (lr = 0.001667)
Hardware	NVIDIA Tesla T4 GPU
AMP	Enabled (mixed precision)
Parameters	3,011,238 (~3M)

C. Threat Classification Module

Post detection, each bounding box is assigned a threat severity level derived from its confidence score. The classification thresholds were empirically selected based on inspection of the model's output distribution on the validation set:

• HIGH THREAT: confidence > 0.70

• MEDIUM THREAT: confidence > 0.40

• LOW THREAT: confidence ≤ 0.40

During inference on the test image (test.jpeg), the model correctly identified a Handgun with confidence > 0.70, resulting in a HIGH THREAT classification, demonstrating the practical utility of the severity overlay.

Fig. 1. High Threat Detection: Handgun detected with a confidence score of 0.91.

Furthermore, real-time testing via webcam successfully captured edged weapons under varying environmental conditions. For instance, a detection yielding a confidence score of 0.34 is appropriately categorised as a LOW THREAT, validating the multi-tiered classification logic.

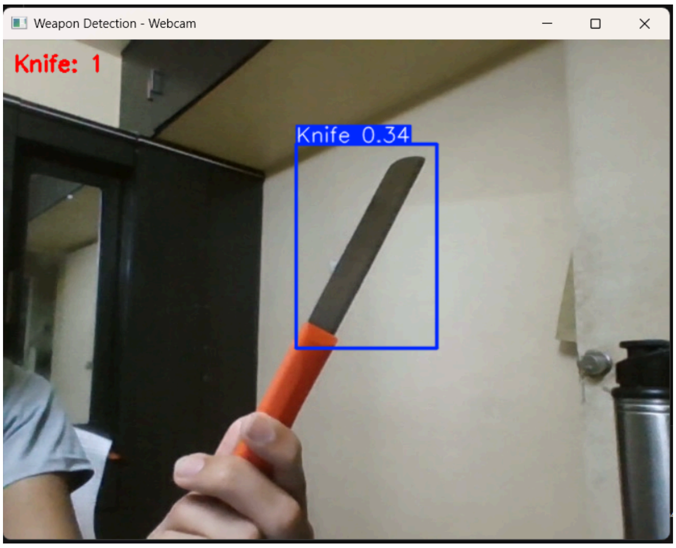

Fig. 2. Low/Medium Threat Detection: Real-time webcam interface demonstrating knife detection with a confidence score of 0.34 and active instance counting.

V. EXPERIMENTS AND RESULTS

A. Detection Performance

The progression of these performance metrics over the training period is visualised in Fig. 3. The steady upward trend across Precision, Recall, and mean Average Precision corroborates the model's stable learning trajectory, culminating in the overall mAP@0.5 of 0.690. A temporary dip in mAP around epoch 21 coincides with the disabling of mosaic augmentation after epoch 20, a known behaviour in YOLOv8 training pipelines that typically self-corrects within a few epochs.

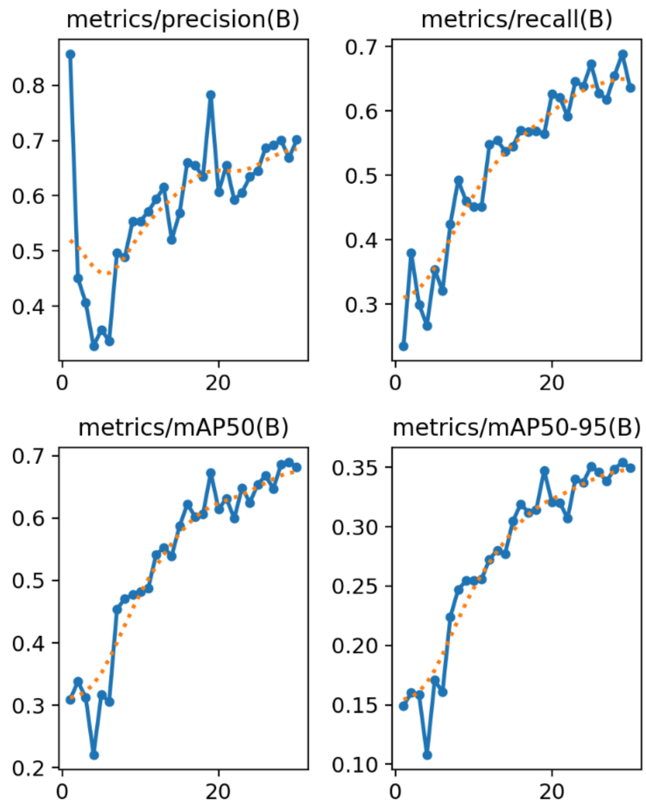

Fig. 3. Validation metrics over 30 epochs, illustrating consistent improvements in Precision, Recall, mAP@0.5, and mAP@0.5:0.95.

The model was evaluated on the 156-image validation set following training completion. The best-performing checkpoint (best.pt, 6.2 MB) was selected based on highest mAP@0.5 across all epochs. Inference speed was measured at 3.2 ms per image (excluding pre- and post-processing), confirming suitability for real-time applications. Table II presents the per-class and overall detection metrics.

TABLE II Detection Performance on Validation Set

Class	Precision	Recall	mAP@0.5	mAP@0.5:0.95
All	0.670	0.693	0.690	0.354
Knife	0.645	0.686	0.628	0.226
Handgun	0.695	0.700	0.751	0.483

Handgun achieved a notably higher mAP@0.5 (0.751) compared to Knife (0.628). This disparity is attributed to the more consistent shape and visual appearance of handguns across training samples, whereas knives exhibit greater morphological variability in blade shape, size, and orientation.

B. Training Dynamics

Training loss curves demonstrated stable convergence. As depicted in Fig. 4, the training box loss decreased from 1.265 (epoch 1) to 0.939 (epoch 30), while the classification loss fell from 2.312 to 0.777, indicating effective learning of class-discriminative features. The DFL (Distribution Focal Loss) similarly decreased from 1.537 to 1.294, reflecting improved bounding box regression accuracy.

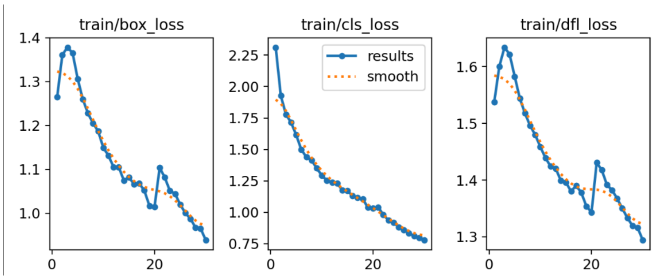

Fig. 4. Training loss components (box_loss, cls_loss, dfl_loss) demonstrating stable convergence over 30 epochs.

Corresponding validation losses are presented in Fig. 5. The parallel descent of the validation curves confirms that the model generalised effectively to unseen data without exhibiting severe overfitting tendencies during the 30-epoch run.

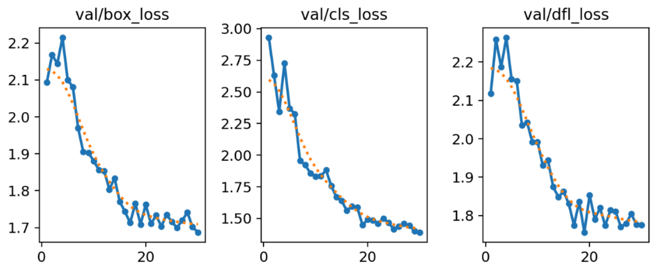

Fig. 5. Validation loss components (box_loss, cls_loss, dfl_loss) recorded over 30 epochs.

C. Comparative Analysis

Table III compares the proposed system with baseline detection architectures. YOLOv8n achieves a superior mAP@0.5 over YOLOv5n while maintaining inference speed well within real-time bounds. Faster R-CNN, though competitive in accuracy, is orders of magnitude slower and is not viable for live surveillance feeds.

TABLE III Comparative Analysis with Baseline Models

Model	Params (M)	mAP@0.5	Inf. Speed (ms)
YOLOv5n	1.9	~0.58	~6.0
YOLOv8n (Ours)	3.0	0.690	3.2
Faster R-CNN	137	~0.65	~80

VI. DISCUSSION

The experimental results confirm that YOLOv8n, despite its lightweight design (~3M parameters), is capable of meaningful weapon detection when fine-tuned with sufficient domain-specific data. The 3.2 ms inference latency positions this system as deployable on mid-tier edge hardware, including devices such as NVIDIA Jetson Nano or Raspberry Pi 4 with appropriate quantisation.

A key limitation of the current system is the small and potentially imbalanced validation set (156 images, 190 instances). The relatively low mAP@0.5:0.95 values (0.354 overall) suggest that localisation precision degrades at stricter IoU thresholds, which is expected for a nano-scale model.

Future iterations should target mAP@0.5:0.95 > 0.50 by expanding the dataset, employing data synthesis (e.g., CycleGAN-based weapon insertion), and experimenting with the YOLOv8s or YOLOv8m variants.

The confidence-based threat classification, while functional, is a heuristic approach. Calibrated probability estimation (e.g., via Platt scaling or temperature scaling) could improve the reliability of threat-level assignments in operational deployments where false positives carry significant cost.

VII. CONCLUSION

This paper presented a real-time weapon detection pipeline based on transfer learning with YOLOv8n, achieving mAP@0.5 of 0.690 across Knife and Handgun categories with an inference speed of 3.2 ms per image. The integrated confidence-based threat classification module adds an interpretable decision layer suitable for surveillance operators. The system demonstrates that lightweight modern architectures can deliver actionable detection performance on domain-specific tasks without requiring large-scale infrastructure.

Future work will focus on: (i) extending the dataset to include additional weapon classes such as rifles and batons; (ii) integrating the system with RTSP surveillance camera streams via an edge deployment module; (iii) applying model quantisation (INT8) for Jetson-class deployment; and (iv) incorporating temporal context using multi-frame tracking to reduce false positives in video feeds.

Acknowledgment

The author thanks MIT World Peace University, Pune, for academic support, and acknowledges Google Colab for providing GPU compute resources used in this research.

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